

Reactive Onboarding

What is it?

Teaching users about features *after* they naturally interact or discover them.

History

Reactive onboarding became popular as products realized that dumping all features upfront causes overload. This approach evolved to help users learn gradually inside real context rather than inside an intro tutorial.

The Psychology Behind It

Human attention is limited. When people are forced to memorize too much too early, retention drops fast. Reactive onboarding works because it teaches only what is needed in the moment. It reduces overwhelm, increases curiosity, and supports natural learning based on user-driven actions.

Why It Matters

- Higher feature adoption
- Smooth learning curve
- Less frustration
- Better confidence
- Reduced early drop-offs

How to Apply It

- Tooltips + contextual hints
- Adaptive onboarding based on actions
- Personalized micro-instruction
- Encourage exploration instead of step-by-step forcing

Theory in Action

Slack reveals feature hints only when hovering over buttons.
Grammarly teaches through real-time corrections as users type.

Final Thought

When people discover on their own, learning becomes easier and more enjoyable. Showing the right help at the right moment is more effective than showing everything upfront.

